A Few Notes

It is a convention to prefix ‘SS’ (Steam Ship) to the names of steamers. To avoid clutter, I have eschewed this practice except in quotations.

Regarding place names, original spellings have been retained in direct quotations. But in my own writing, I have avoided the old, anglicized spelling of ‘Tinnevelly’—virtually unrecognizable to the modern reader—preferring the now common ‘Tirunelveli’. Hence ‘Madurai’ rather than ‘Madura’, ‘Thanjavur’ rather than ‘Tanjore’ and so on. However, ‘Tuticorin’ has been retained as the new, and accurate, spelling, ‘Thoothukudi’ is yet to catch on. Bombay and Calcutta have been used rather than Mumbai and Kolkata, though I have preferred ‘Kakinada’ to ‘Cocanada’, ‘Visakhapatnam’ to ‘Vizagpatam’. Though inconsistent, I believe, this is more reader friendly.

Spelling personal names and caste surnames is even more vexatious: Subramania/Subrahmania/Subrahmanya; Gurusami/Guruswami/Guruswamy; Thambuswamy/Thambusami; Pillai/Pillay; Mudaliar/Mudaliyar; Chettiar/Chettiyar; Iyer/Aiyar/Aiyer; Iyengar/Aiyangar. Except Subramania Bharati who was consistent in spelling his name everyone else invariably tended to be erratic. However, I have preferred Pandithurai Thevar to Pandithorey Thevar as the latter is quaint. Generally, I have opted for current and more common spellings.

All translations from Tamil sources are mine unless noted otherwise.

A note on the worth of money

What was the value of money at that time?

Inflation over more than a century skews our understanding of the relative value of money. Economists use a range of sophisticated methods